



IN DELHI-NCR, as Dr Aashish Chaudhry, Chief Orthopedic Surgeon at Aakash Healthcare, completed his 100th robotic knee surgery of 2024, he couldn't stop marvelling at the millimetre-by-millimetre real-time adjustments he could make with the robotic arm, and the lower soft-tissue trauma created as opposed to traditional surgery. The patient would be up and about in a couple of days, although full flexibility could take up to one-and-a-half years as atrophied muscles need time to recover.

In Kolkata, a retired corporate executive told his buddies at the club, "Sorry, I have to go home now." What! They exclaimed. It's just 9 pm! The 65-year-old retorted, "After my recent illness, my son gave me this wrist-watch, and he can monitor my health and bedtime from Bengaluru!"

From robots to wristwatches, change is coursing through India's healthcare sector.

Amitabh Dube, Country President and Managing Director of pharmaceuticals major Novartis India, a unit of Switzerland's Novartis, sees healthcare become more patient-centric and technology-driven. Dube is betting on three crucial trends: the digital revolution, universal healthcare coverage, and a focus on preventive and targeted therapy.

"Telemedicine and integration of AI will improve accessibility, particularly in remote areas. AI-driven diagnostics, personalised treatment plans, and virtual consultations will allow patients to receive timely care without extensive travel," says Dube.

But this transformation can happen only if there is a database and someone to pay for the technology. Enter the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission, which is creating a unified health information system of electronic health records. Ayushman Bharat aims to offer a cover of up to ₹5 lakh per family to 100 million families for secondary and tertiary hospitalisation.

Dube sees the government expanding universal healthcare coverage. "Policies like Ayushman Bharat will evolve to cover a broader range of services," he says, supported by public-private partnerships (PPPs) to create better infrastructure and affordable healthcare.

Third, better preventive care will reduce the burden on the system. Preventive care ranges from basic hygiene and wellness programmes to early disease detection and personalised medicine. "Public health campaigns, early screening programmes, and lifestyle interventions will promote healthier lifestyles and early intervention," Dube says.

The India Brand Equity Foundation says the healthcare sector is projected to reach ₹16.4 lakh crore (\$200 billion) by 2025, including pharmaceuticals, medical devices, and healthcare services. India's healthcare expenditure is currently around 2.1% of GDP. The sector includes over 700,000 healthcare facilities and 1.8 million hospital beds, of which the private sector manages about 70%. Major players

HEALTHCARE @ 100: A SNAPSHOT



Tech-driven Healthcare
India's healthcare is advancing with AI and telemedicine to improve access and patient care



Universal Coverage Expansion:
Government initiatives aim to broaden healthcare coverage, making advanced treatments more accessible nationwide



Personalised Medicine Growth
Advances in genomics and biotechnology are driving the shift towards more tailored and effective treatments



Pharma Sector Expansion:
The industry is focussing on innovative therapies and sustainable practices to address major health issues



Diagnostics Improvement
Point-of-care and digital diagnostics are enhancing accuracy and accessibility



Infra Enhancement
Development of smart hospitals and improved infrastructure is aimed at bridging urban-rural healthcare gaps